Sinners in the Hands of an Angry God

Jonathan Edwards · July 8, 1741 (Enfield, Connecticut)

Source: Jonathan Edwards, Sinners in the Hands of an Angry God (1741), text via Project Gutenberg (#34632). Public domain.

Preached at the height of the First Great Awakening, Edwards's sermon used vivid, terrifying imagery to drive listeners toward personal conversion. The Awakening's emotional, revivalist style swept the colonies, challenged established churches, and created a shared religious experience that crossed colonial lines — an early step toward a common colonial identity.

Connect: How did the emotional, revivalist style of the Great Awakening differ from an older Puritan sermon like Winthrop's?

Key Passages

Nothing but God's pleasure

> There is nothing that keeps wicked men at any one moment out of hell, but the mere pleasure of God. … There is nothing between you and hell but the air; 'tis only the power and mere pleasure of God that holds you up.

The spider over the fire

> The God that holds you over the pit of hell, much as one holds a spider or some loathsome insect over the fire, abhors you, and is dreadfully provoked; his wrath towards you burns like fire; … You have offended him infinitely more than ever a stubborn rebel did his prince: and yet it is nothing but his hand that holds you from falling into the fire every moment.

A call to conversion

> And now you have an extraordinary opportunity, a day wherein Christ has flung the door of mercy wide open, and stands in the door calling and crying with a loud voice to poor sinners; … How awful is it to be left behind at such a day! To see so many others feasting, while you are pining and perishing! … Therefore let every one that is out of Christ now awake and fly from the wrath to come.

HIPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	The First Great Awakening (1730s-40s): revivals swept the colonies, challenging established churches and the cooler, more rational religion of the Enlightenment era.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	His congregation and the Enfield, Connecticut, church audience, whom he saw as spiritually complacent and unconverted; it was later printed for a wider readership.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	Jonathan Edwards, a Calvinist minister and theologian and leading revivalist, who believed people were saved only by God's grace through a personal conversion.
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. SAQ practice (A·C·E): Explain ONE effect of the First Great Awakening on colonial society.
2. Why might Edwards's vivid imagery have been so effective with his audience?
3. How did the Great Awakening help create a shared identity across the separate colonies?